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COMMUNITY - Solano County urges action on food cuts

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Just one week after Congressman John Garamendi visited the Contra Costa-Solano County Food Bank to decry sweeping federal cuts to nutrition assistance programs, Solano County leaders have formally urged state lawmakers to take swift action to shield CalFresh recipients from the fallout of President Donald Trump's "Big Beautiful Bill."

In a letter signed by Board of Supervisors Chairman Mitch Mashburn and sent to key members of the California Legislature's budget committees — Assembly members Jesse Gabriel and Corey Jackson, and State Senators Scott Wiener and Akilah Weber Pierson — the county officials sounded the alarm over what they called "harmful federal changes" to the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), known as CalFresh in California.

"The County of Solano respectfully urges our immediate action in response to harmful federal changes to (CalFresh) enacted under H.R. 1," the letter begins, warning that unless the state steps in with funding before the end of the current legislative session, tens of thousands of vulnerable residents could face food insecurity.

More than 54,000 Solano County residents currently rely on CalFresh benefits — part of a broader group of programs serving one in three local residents, according to county data.

At the heart of the concern is H.R. 1, a Republican-led budget package signed into law by President Trump. Among its many provisions, the bill significantly expands time limits and work requirements for "Able-Bodied Adults Without Dependents (ABAWDs)" (now including individuals ages 55—64 and parents of teenagers ages 14—18). The bill also eliminates exemptions for veterans, the homeless and former foster youth.

"Preserving this assistance is not just a policy matter — it is critical to public health and community stability," the supervisors wrote. "Interruptions in food support drive food insecurity, which harms health, child development, and economic productivity."

$90.7 million request for FY 2025-26

To manage the coming changes, Solano and other counties are asking the state to allocate $90.7 million from the general fund in the 2025-26 fiscal year. The funding would go toward staffing, training, recipient outreach and expanded administrative work related to new federal requirements.

Among the new responsibilities facing county staff:

Informing recipients of new work requirements and time limits.

Screening for exemptions.

Verifying household utility expenses due to changes in the Standard Utility Allowance (SUA).

Providing referrals to employment and training programs.

Managing more complex eligibility determinations for non-citizens and accounting for new rules on energy cost exclusions.

“Counties must begin staffing up now to ensure recipients are thoroughly informed of the work requirements and supported through the process,” the letter states.

Officials warn that without prompt action, California risks not only a spike in hunger but also costly federal penalties.

Research shows that complex SNAP rule changes often lead to increased Payment Error Rates (PER), which in turn raise state liabilities, the letter notes. Under the new federal law California could face up to $2 billion in increased costs if its error rates rise, with those liabilities beginning in 2027, but being calculated based on actions taken starting this fiscal year.

Impact on local communities

County leaders say the urgency is real. Without intervention, they warn, CalFresh recipients in Solano and across the state could begin losing benefits as early as next year, undermining food security for children, seniors, and low-income families already struggling with inflation and rising housing costs.

“Absent state action, H.R. 1 will increase hunger among children, families, and seniors, and destabilize CalFresh county operations,” the letter says. “We urge you to adopt this critical budget action to protect California’s most vulnerable families and communities.”

The letter echoes concerns raised by Congressman Garamendi during his recent visit to the local food bank, where he criticized what he called “cruel and unnecessary” cuts targeting the most vulnerable.

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